BACKGROUND READING · AGRICULTURAL TRADE & CITRUS EXPORTS

From grove to global market: how countries compete in citrus fruit exports

A look at the international trade in citrus fruits — oranges, lemons, grapefruits, and other varieties — and why a small number of countries dominate each category.

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subject synonym — single underline	**numerical language** — bold + underline	*Task 1 chunk* — italic + underline

The global trade in citrus produce is worth tens of billions of dollars annually, yet it is dominated by a surprisingly small number of exporting nations. Oranges, lemons, grapefruits, and a range of other citrus varieties are grown across warm-climate regions from the Mediterranean to Latin America and East Asia, but when it comes to international shipments, **only a handful of countries** consistently appear at the top of the rankings. *What is immediately striking is that* the leading exporters differ considerably depending on the fruit category — a country that dominates orange exports may barely feature in the lemon or grapefruit markets.

Oranges — the heavyweight category

Of all citrus commodities, oranges represent **by far the largest volumes** traded internationally. *It is clear that* African and Middle Eastern producers have carved out a significant position in this segment of the market. South Africa, in particular, has become one of the world's leading orange exporters, **consistently shipping well over a thousand thousand tonnes** to destinations across Europe and Asia. Egypt also features among the top exporters, though its export volumes are **noticeably lower** than South Africa's. *By contrast,* the United States — despite being a major domestic producer — ranks **considerably below** both African nations in terms of outbound orange shipments, suggesting that much of its crop is consumed domestically rather than exported.

Lemons and grapefruits — different leaders emerge

What the data reveal, however, is that the rankings shift considerably when attention turns to other citrus types. In the lemon trade, Mexico emerges as the clear leader, **outpacing** both the United States and Argentina — two nations that barely registered in the orange export rankings at all. *This suggests that* climatic conditions and agricultural specialisation in different regions make certain countries better suited to particular varieties. Argentina's citrus industry, for example, is heavily oriented towards lemons rather than oranges, which explains its appearance in one category but not the other.

Grapefruits present yet another picture. *In contrast to* the lemon market, where Latin American producers lead, Turkey ranks **at the very top** of grapefruit exports, with **volumes substantially higher** than Mexico or the United States. *It is worth noting that* Turkey is **rarely among the top exporters** in the other three categories, making it an interesting outlier — a nation with a highly specialised export profile concentrated in a single fruit segment.

The 'others' category — Mexico's breadth

Perhaps *the most notable pattern of all is* the dominance of Mexico across multiple categories. While no single country leads in every fruit type, Mexico appears in **three of the four** charts — lemons, grapefruits, and the catch-all 'other citrus' segment. *This points to* a **broad and diversified** citrus export industry, rather than one built around a single crop. Egypt, *on the other hand,* appears in both oranges and other citrus but with **far smaller volumes** in the latter, indicating that oranges remain its **dominant** export commodity.

Reading four charts as one response

One of the key challenges this task presents is deciding how to structure a response that covers four separate charts. *Rather than describing each chart in turn,* the strongest responses group the information thematically — for example, by identifying which countries appear across multiple categories, or by comparing the **scale of volumes** across fruit types. *It is also important to note that* the axes differ between charts — oranges are measured in **far higher quantities** than the others — so directly comparing absolute figures requires care. *Overall, the picture that emerges is one of* specialisation: each exporting nation tends to concentrate its trade in one or two varieties rather than dominating across the board, with Mexico being the notable exception as a genuinely **multi-category** exporter.

Key figures to anchor your response	
~1,500 thousand t	Oranges — South Africa (largest single bar across all four charts)
~500 thousand t	Lemons — Mexico (category leader)
~450 thousand t	Grapefruits — Turkey (category leader)

Mexico	Only country appearing in 3 of 4 categories — key overview point
Axes differ!	Oranges scale (0–1500) vs others (0–500/600) — avoid false comparisons

Subject synonyms (underlined in the article above)	
Instead of 'country'	nation · state · producer · exporting country · economy
Instead of 'exports'	shipments · trade · output · volumes · supply · deliveries
Instead of 'fruit type'	category · variety · citrus type · commodity · segment · produce
Instead of 'amount'	volume · quantity · figure · total · level
Instead of 'highest'	the leading · the top · the dominant · the largest · the greatest

Numerical language (bold + underlined in the article above)	
by far the largest / highest of all	considerably below / noticeably lower than
only a handful of countries	three of the four categories
volumes substantially higher than	far smaller / much lower in absolute terms
outpacing all others	broad and diversified / multi-category

Task 1 chunks (italic + underlined in the article above)	
What is immediately striking is that …	It is clear that …
What the data reveal, however, is that …	This suggests that …
In contrast to [noun], …	By contrast, …
It is worth noting that …	The most notable pattern of all is …
Rather than describing each chart in turn, …	Overall, the picture that emerges is one of …
This points to …	On the other hand, …

Legend: underline only = subject synonym · bold + underline = numerical language · italic + underline = Task 1 chunk